

Out of desperation, we decided to talk to some potential customers. We brought them into our office, and said, “Try this new product; it’s IMVU.” If the person was a teenager, a heavy user of IM, or a tech early adopter, he or she would engage with us. In contrast, if it was a mainstream person, the response was, “Right. So exactly what would you like me to do?” We’d get nowhere with the mainstream group; they thought IMVU was too weird.

Imagine a seventeen-year-old girl sitting down with us to look at this product. She chooses her avatar and says, “Oh, this is really fun.” She’s customizing the avatar, deciding how she’s going to look. Then we say, “All right, it’s time to download the instant messaging add-on,” and she responds, “What’s that?”

“Well, it’s this thing that interoperates with the instant messaging client.” She’s looking at us and thinking, “I’ve never heard of that, my friends have never heard of that, why do you want me to do that?” It required a lot of explanation; an instant messaging add-on was not a product category that existed in her mind.

But since she was in the room with us, we were able to talk her into doing it. She downloads the product, and then we say, “Okay, invite one of your friends to chat.” And she says, “No way!” We say, “Why not?” And she says, “Well, I don’t know if this thing is cool yet. You want me to risk inviting one of my friends? What are they going to think of me? If it sucks, they’re going to think I suck, right?” And we say, “No, no, it’s going to be so much fun once you get the person in there; it’s a social product.” She looks at us, her face filled with doubt; you can see that this is a deal breaker. Of course, the first time I had that experience, I said, “It’s all right, it’s just this one person, send her away and get me a new one.” Then the second customer comes in and says the same thing. Then the third customer comes in, and it’s the same thing. You start to see patterns, and no matter how stubborn you are, there’s obviously something wrong.

Customers kept saying, “I want to use it by myself. I want to try it out first to see if it’s really cool before I invite a friend.” Our team was from the video game industry, so we understood what that meant: single-player mode. So we built a single-player version.